



Incident handler's journal

Instructions

As you continue through this course, you may use this template to record your findings after completing an activity or to take notes on what you've learned about a specific tool or concept. You can also use this journal as a way to log the key takeaways about the different cybersecurity tools or concepts you encounter in this course.

Date: October 29 th , 2025	Entry: #1
Description	An employee opened a phishing email that contained a malware spreadsheet. After obtaining the file, I generated a SHA256 hash and used VirusTotal to verify that it was malicious. Related domains and URLs were marked for additional examination.
Tool(s) used	SHA256 hashing tool, VirusTotal
The 5 W's	• Who was responsible for the incident? A phishing email with a malicious spreadsheet attachment was delivered by a threat actor. • What took place? A payload was activated on the employee's device after they downloaded and viewed a malicious spreadsheet. • When was the incident? The file was opened earlier today, April 23, 2025, after the email was received. • Where was the incident that occurred? The incident took place on a financial services firm employee's workstation. • Why did it happen? Because the phishing email included the password and looked reliable, it was successful in tricking the employee into opening the infected file.
Additional notes	1. By putting in place more robust email filtering systems, providing frequent security awareness training to help staff recognize phishing efforts, and keeping safe, offline backups of important data for simpler recovery, the organization can stop such events in the future.

	2. The majority of law enforcement organizations, including the FBI, and cybersecurity experts advise against paying the ransom. Paying the criminals makes the company a willing target for future attacks and does not ensure that the decryption key will be supplied or work.
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